subsequent editions commissioned by succeeding dynasties right up to the Qing (1644–1911). These Illustrations contained artistic representations of foreign envoys paying homage to the imperial court, but were a mixture of facts, remembrances from past editions of the Illustrations or plain fiction. The visit of a trader from the Byzantine empire during the Northern Song dynasty (960–1127 CE) was enough to have it included as a vassal state in the dynasty's edition of the Illustrations. As pointed out by a contemporary Chinese scholar, Ge Zhaoguang, 'Images of foreign emissaries were used to convey the Celestial Empire's sense of pride and self-confidence, with representations of strange customs from foreign countries serving as a foil for the image of China as a radiant universal empire at the centre of the world.' There is no historical documentation to reveal how the 'tributary' states saw the relationship. At least one well-known Song dynasty literati, Su Shih (also known as Su Dongpo), saw through the ritual:

> They pretend to come and pay tribute because they admire our righteousness but what they are really after is profit. [3]

The Illustrations engendered a deeply ingrained Chinese prism through which the world came to be perceived. And again, in the words of Ge Zhaoguang:

> Despite the fact that the modern Chinese nation-state broke away from the central imperial system, the traditional idea of China as an empire at the centre of the world managed to survive this transformation. [4]

It is these persistent imaginings which drive Xi Jinping's China Dream.

What is also worth noting is the manner in which Western scholarship on China has reinforced this narrative, in particular the writings of John King Fairbank. Fairbank posited the tribute system as a wellspring of a uniquely Chinese theory of international relations. He put forward the idea of an East Asian order of tributary states that centred on China creating a Chinese world order. This tacitly acknowledged Sino-centrism as an organizing principle of the East Asian order, even though the reality through history, and the present-day constellation of independent sovereign states, belies that centrism. [5]

Inherent in this tributary system is the notion of hierarchy, which applies